Matthew Brown

CONTACT INFORMATION

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APPOINTMENTS

Assistant Instructional Professor, University of Chicago, Department of Economics 2025-

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, Stanford University 2019-2025
Advisors: Matthew Gentzkow, Hunt Allcott, Doug Bernheim

B.A. in Mathematics and Economics, University of Notre Dame 2015-2019

AFFILIATIONS

Research Advisory Council, Boys and Men Online
Invited Researcher, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab

WORKING PAPERS

Do Sports Bettors Need Consumer Protection? Evidence From A Field Experiment (with Nick Grasley and Mariana Guido)

Revise and Resubmit, *Review of Economic Studies*

Abstract: We conduct a field experiment with high-volume sports bettors to study how biases impact sports betting demand and evaluate corrective policy interventions. We find substantial overoptimism about financial returns: the average participant predicts that they will break even, but loses 7.5 cents for every dollar wagered. We also find evidence of self-control problems, though these are quantitatively smaller. Our estimates imply that surplus-maximizing taxes on sports betting are about twice as large as prevailing taxes. Though targeted interventions can improve efficiency relative to uniform taxes, experimental evidence shows that two specific interventions favored by the gambling industry are ineffective.

Can Online Activity Be Regulated? Evidence From Adult Websites (with Emily Davis and Devin G. Pope)

Abstract: The consequences of online regulations depend on the extent to which users can circumvent restrictions or substitute toward noncompliant platforms. Since 2023, 25 U.S. states have implemented age verification laws that caused prominent adult websites (including Pornhub) to restrict local access for all users. We study how these restrictions affected browsing activity using individual-level panel data. Access restrictions reduced overall time spent on adult sites by roughly 10%. Specifically, for every 100 hours spent on top adult sites before restrictions, about 50 hours remained accessible at noncompliant sites that never restricted access, 30 hours persisted through VPN-based circumvention, 10 hours were substituted from compliant sites to noncompliant sites, and 10 hours were no longer spent on adult sites.

Tax Design, Efficiency, and Incidence in Sports Betting (with Jeffrey Ohl)

Abstract: Most U.S. states with legal sports betting tax sportsbook revenue. We show that this ad valorem tax behaves like a profits tax because sportsbooks' costs per dollar wagered are small. Sportsbooks do not raise the price of betting in high-tax states. Instead, they spend less on local TV advertising. We estimate the effects of these advertising reductions on sportsbook deposits. We compare the ad valorem tax to a specific tax, accounting for tax-induced advertising reductions and gambling internalities. The specific tax would increase prices and discourage more betting, but its corrective benefits do not outweigh its conventional efficiency costs.

The Role of Political Ideology in Media Coverage of Science (with Harsh Gupta)

Abstract: We study the role of political ideology in the diffusion of scientific knowledge by media outlets. We document, using a novel measure of scientist ideology that spans more than 600,000 papers, that outlets are statistically significantly more likely to cover scientists with similar ideology. However, the role of scientist ideology is small in magnitude when compared to the role of scientific quality, as measured by academic citations, journal quality, and research funding, in media coverage of science. On average, outlets are more likely to cover high-quality research written by misaligned scientists than low-quality research written by ideologically aligned scientists.

Selected Work In Progress

Pornography, Self-Control, and Welfare: Experimental Evidence (with Emily Davis and Joshua Grubbs)
Status: Funded and piloting

Teaching Experience

University of Chicago

Behavioral Economics and Welfare Analysis	2025, 2026
Principles of Microeconomics	2026
Consumers, Firms, and the Environment	2026

Stanford University

TA for Junior Honors Seminar	2025
TA for Undergraduate Behavioral Economics (x3)	2022-2024
TA for Undergraduate Empirical Environmental Economics (x2)	2023
TA for Bing Honors College Undergraduate Thesis Boot Camp	2023
TA for Undergraduate Principles of Economics	2021
Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award (x4)	2022 - 2024

Awards & Fellowships

Social Sciences Well-Being Gift, American Institute for Boys and Men	2026
Kenneth C Griffin Applied Economics Incubator Award, University of Chicago	2025
Internet Pornography and Well-Being Pilot Grant, American Institute for Boys and Men	2025
Woods Institute Emerging Environmental Scholar Research Award, Stanford University	2025
Responsible Gaming Grant, Colorado Division of Gaming	2024
Ethics in Society Graduate Research Grant, Stanford University	2024
Bill Lane Center for the American West Grant, Stanford University	2024
George P. Shultz Dissertation Support Fund Fellowship, Stanford University	2023
Roger Noll Dissertation Fellowship, Stanford University	2023
Stanford Center for American Democracy (SCAD) Experiment Grant, Stanford University	2021
Center on Philanthropy and Civil Society (PACS) Small Grant, Stanford University	2021
Institute for Research in the Social Sciences (IRiSS) Research Data Grant, Stanford University	2021
Bernoulli Senior Thesis Award (Honorable Mention), Notre Dame	2019
Open Source Macroeconomics Boot Camp (Student Fellow), University of Chicago	2018

Invited Presentations

2026:
Econometric Society North American Meeting, MIT (Applied Micro Seminar), DePaul University, New Tools for Studying Digital Interactions Webinar (with Boys & Men Online and the Psychology of Technology Institute), Porn Research & Policy Meeting

2025:
Analysis Group, Edgeworth Economics, University of Wisconsin, University of Notre Dame, Bates White, National Conference on Gambling Addiction & Responsible Gambling, Macalester College, University of Chicago Booth

2023:

University of Notre Dame

REFEREEING *Journal of Gambling Studies, Journal of Public Economics, Journal of Political Economy: Microeconomics*